

What is Linguistics?

State University of New York at Stony Brook



Let's Get Started!



"We'll start out by speaking in simple declarative sentences."

What is Linguistics?

- Linguistics is the **Science of Human Language**.
- What is Human Language?

In order to identify what role linguistic structure plays within the totality of language, we must consider the individual act of speech and trace what takes place in the speech circuit. This act requires at least two individuals: without this minimum the circuit would not be complete. Suppose, then, we have two people, *A* and *B*, talking to each other:



The starting point of the circuit is in the brain of one individual, for instance *A*, where facts of consciousness which we shall call concepts

Excerpt from Ferdinand de Saussure's (1916) *Course in General Linguistics*

What is Human Language?

Here are some ways language was defined in the past:

- Aristotle: A system of symbols that refer to things in the actual world which humans use to express their thoughts and communicate
- Saussure: A structured mental system of signs, where the meaning of a sign depends on its relationship to other signs rather than to what the sign refers to in the actual world



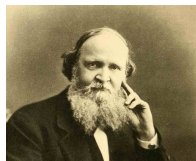
Aristotle (384-322 BC)



Ferdinand de Saussure (1857-1913)

What is Human Language?

- Whitney: A tool for communication that evolves overtime to meet the needs of its speakers
- Sapir: A purely human method of communication that is deeply intertwined with culture and thought; language influences how speakers think and make sense of the world



Dwight Whitney (1827-1894)



Edward Sapir (1884-1939)

What is Human Language?

- Bloomfield: A system of behavioral habits used for communication that are learned as responses to stimuli
- Chomsky: An computational system in the human mind; all humans have an innate capacity for language that allows children to effortlessly and rapidly learn whatever language they are exposed to



Leonard Bloomfield (1887-1949)



Noam Chomsky (1928-)

How do We Study Human Language

- In this course, we will be exploring the following:
 - ① What exactly do we know when we “know” a language?
 - ② How did we learn or acquire language?
 - ③ How is language used?

Example

Here are three possible hypotheses to the following question: *What exactly have we acquired, when we know a language?*

- Hypothesis 1: We have acquired a set of social conventions (Whitney)
- Hypothesis 2: We have acquired a set of behavioral habits (Bloomfield)
- Hypothesis 3: We have acquired a mental system of signs or symbols (Saussure, Chomsky)

What do I need to know from this module for the exam?

- Content from this module will not be on the exam